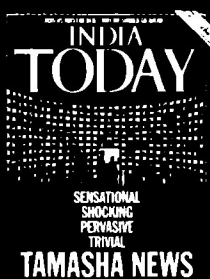
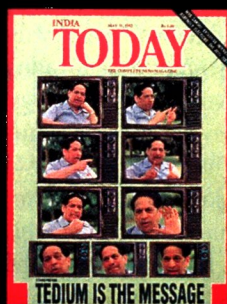


10

stories that changed in our lifetime

Television went from monolith to multiplicity. Mrs Gandhi went from chief despot to supreme saviour and our stories somersaulted to keep up with the change. Ten stories that did an about turn on our pages.

1982-2006



OUT OF THE BOX

From the monopolistic, monochromatic Doordarshan, India moved to 24-hour tamasha news

All India had to offer in the initial years of television was the lacklustre Doordarshan that hardly provided any entertainment. It was in the 1980s that the Government finally woke up to the power of its broadcasting monopoly. "The Government is suddenly rushing to make up for lost time in expanding the tentacles of Doordarshan. The sizeable swelling of Doordarshan's budget in 1980-81 to 1982-83 (Rs 5 crore to Rs 14 crore) reflects the will, the determination of the I&B Ministry to find resources for the state-monopoly television network's mushroom growth," said INDIA TODAY in May 1982. That was then. Twenty-four years later, in December 2006, INDIA TODAY went on to say, "In their drive to cater to new viewing preferences, news channels have redefined news and transformed lives. For better or worse." With the new-found information revolution, aspirations for a free and autonomous media had been fulfilled. "A study by public relations firm Edelman shows that 49 per cent Indians tune in to tv first for trustworthy news, compared to just 31 per cent in Asia Pacific," stated the article. It was the coming of age for the medium. It was late, and had several false starts but tv had finally arrived in India.

Viewers look for titillation in news which is why we show a lot of cinema and crime.

LAXMI NARAIN GOEL,

MANAGING DIRECTOR, ZEE NEWS LTD, 2006

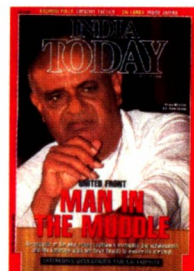
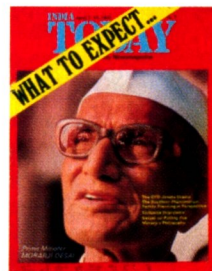
FLEETING ALLIANCES

From the disunited Janata Party to the fractious United Front, coalition politics came to stay

Ideally for a country as big as India, coalition governments remain the most suitable form of governance, effective in enhancing democratic legitimacy and national unity. But with the decline in Congress's domination and fragmentation of the national party system, India turned into a federal chessboard. The country got a taste of coalition politics in 1977, when Morarji Desai was declared the first prime minister of the country who did not belong to the Congress. "On March 26, at midnight, a roar went up from the crowds in front of newspaper offices as the prime minister announced 19 members

of his team. At the swearing-in ceremony however, five were absent. Then for two days, political horse-trading delayed the course of history," the article said further. The government did not last. Desai led a fractious coalition government, and thus failed to achieve much. Almost two decades later, in 1996 when Deve Gowda came to power, history repeated itself. INDIA TODAY questioned the unity of his United Front coalition: "The prime minister will have to negotiate a minefield of political interests to ensure that his government works." He couldn't. It didn't.

1977-1996



"It is a testing time for people; they have to decide which way they want to take the country."

INDIRA GANDHI

DURING HER CAMPAIGN IN RAE BARELI, 1977